

Afterimage

By

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INT. CLASSROOM - DAY

Students sit inside a neutrally lit classroom. A middle-aged man wearing glasses, a buttoned up shirt, and jeans stands next to a white board with rows of students in front of him. On the whiteboard is written "Deliverables: Fixed focus roll. Shoot an entire roll using only one focal distance" as the man standing next to it periodically points at the board.

TEACHER

For this assignment you'll load one roll and pick a single focus distance. Do not change it. You'll shoot the entire roll using only your aperture to control the shot.

As the teacher continues speaking, a faint hum slowly cuts through and replaces the teacher's voice. The teacher's mouth is moving but all sounds are muffled. A student sitting in the back of the class, early 20s brown hair, and a tired look on their face, leaning on their desk, opens their notebook, and on a blank page writes "focus distance" and underlines it. They look up, as they're unsure about what's written, and then looks back at the page to underline their writing twice, but then looks at a student next to them to see if he also wrote the same in his notebook.

CUT TO:

EXT. BEACH - DAY

the student, wearing a black hoodie and denim jeans is walking on the beach, heading towards the shoreline. They're wearing a backpack with both straps on their shoulders and has a tripod bag hanging off their right shoulder above the backpack strap. In their left hand they're holding a camera bag. As they walk along the beach, their feet kicks up sand and their shoes begin to get coated in it. The student slows their pace and stops in their tracks and looks at the horizon before setting their bag down and setting up the tripod, and as they set it up, they unnecessarily adjust it, eager to get it to be perfect. They fit the camera on top and begin to set the camera's settings to what they want and then looks up at the horizon, envisioning the perfect shot, as they hear the study hush of the surf, the waves crashing in the distance, and seagulls cawing. They take in a deep breath, hesitate for a second, and then kneels down and looks into the viewfinder of the camera and adjusts focus. The perspective shifts to a P.O.V. as the student brings the image into sharp focus. They keep it in focus for a couple seconds until the steady sounds of the beach are replaced by a disruptive and chaotic hum.

flashes begin to pop up in front of the image of the horizon and different sounds steadily creep in. displays of visuals and sounds that are in some way related to the image the student is trying to capture. a video of the student in class as the teacher gives the assignment. a flash of the student talking to another student. a flash of the student talking to another person in a completely different setting that is in no way related to academia or the assignment, the theme of the intrusions start with things relevant to the matter at hand, then identity based ones like memories and interests, to finally, self-judgement based ones, like past failures and rejection, each connected to the one before it in some way. The intrusions start off in a stable and legible way, but as they come close to an end, they're fragmented, looping, and distorted. This cluster of visuals and sounds become chaotic and overstimulating both visually and aurally. This sequence continues for an unnervingly long couple minutes before it is all ended as the sound of a camera shutter cuts through it all.

CUT TO BLACK

INT. PRINTING STORE - DAY

The student walks into a printing store and stands at a counter. A shopkeeper is standing behind the counter stapling large stacks of papers together. The shopkeeper looks up at the student, and, without speaking, walks away. He returns with a closed khaki envelope and places it on his counter. The student puts down money on the counter, as they look at the envelope. They hesitate for a second, almost as if they know there's something wrong with it, before they reach over and pick it up. The student then pulls the print outs out of it.

CUT TO:

INT. CLASSROOM - DAY

The teacher pulls the prints out of the envelope and looks at flips through them. He looks up at the student while still holding the prints in his hand.

TEACHER (ANNOYED)

What's this? This isn't photography.
This... This is lazy. Do you
understand what "focus" means?
Photography isn't just pointing a
camera and pressing a button. It's
patience, observation, and intention.
This has none of that...

The student nods along as they listens to the teacher, they open their mouth as if they plan to respond, but they stay quiet, listening to the teacher, but as the teacher continues speaking, a faint hum slowly cuts through the dialogue and replaces the teacher's voice as the teacher continues to chew out the student for their sloppy work. The teacher's mouth is, again, moving but all sounds slowly get muffled. The student stands in front of the teacher trying to listen to what he's saying, but their face makes it clear that they're not. Slowly, accompanied by the faint hum, the intrusions begin to pop up again, each one connected to the one before it. but this time they're faster, they're repeating, it's like the teacher's words triggered these intrusions, rather than the student drowning in them. The intrusions devolve into a chaotic mess of sounds and visuals that are, again, overwhelming. These continue on for a minute with the faint mumblings of the teacher in the background, but this time, the intrusions are brought to an abrupt end by the student themself

STUDENT

WHY WON'T YOU EVER JUST SHUT UP?!

As the intrusions suddenly end, the student experiences a second of calm and silence before they realise that the silence isn't only in their mind. They realise that they shouted that out loud while looking at their teacher. The teacher looks back at the student in confusion, not knowing what to do or say after seeing what the student's just done. The teacher looks like he's trying to say something, but is forcing himself to not. The student panics and struggles to get words out to explain themself

STUDENT (CONT'D)

No... I... That wasn't... Sorry...

The student hurriedly picks up their bag and runs out of the class. The teacher's gaze follows the student leave, as the look of confusion remains on his face. The teacher looks at the rest of the class and slowly walks over to his desk to put the prints down, the world feels like it's gone quiet, and the teacher still does not know how to process the events of what just happened. He looks down at the student's work now on his desk, then at the rest of the students, who he had almost forgotten about for a second, then back to the classroom door.

CUT TO BLACK

INT. TEACHERS' ROOM - AFTERNOON

The teacher sits at the end of a table surrounded by his peers. The teachers are discussing amongst themselves the matter of the student and the churlish act of yelling at the teacher in front of the whole class.

TEACHER AT TABLE 1

This is clear disrespect against faculty, this institution should not allow that

TEACHER AT TABLE 2

I agree, this was unacceptable. Not acting on something like this is sending the wrong message to our students

TEACHER AT TABLE 3

I know the student, he's a good kid. Let's be rational here, a slap on the wrist is enough.

TEACHER AT TABLE 4

Good kid or not, this is a one-and-done kind of situation. This is suspension at the very least.

The teacher sits at the end of the table, leaning back into his chair, looking at his peers as they express their opinions on the topic, not participating. The teachers begin to talk over each other, and as the chattering noises grow more chaotic, a faint hum cuts through it all and muffles the sounds as the teacher stays as he was, now looking directly ahead into the camera, almost as if he's seen what the audience and realises what's been happening. He leans forward and looks at his peers.

TEACHER

No. Look... If all we're judging is behaviour, then sure, punishment makes sense

The teacher leans in, thinking to himself

TEACHER (CONT'D)

But... I was there. He said it to me. I saw her. I heard the words. I felt the room freeze. If we saw disrespect, then we weren't looking.

The teacher pauses, lets out a sigh and takes his glasses off, holding them in his hands. He looks at his glasses, not to be dramatic, but to buy time, and then back up at his peers.

TEACHER (CONT'D)

I understand why you see it as disrespect, but she wasn't challenging authority. She yelled, most definitely, but not at me. No, she yelled at something he needed to muster up a lot more effort to silence. She knows she crossed a line... She doesn't need another adult telling her she failed. What she needs is someone to stop for a second and actually see her.

He looks around the table.

TEACHER (CONT'D)

If this is intended to be a place of learning, then sometimes the lesson is not just academic. Sometimes it's patience. Sometimes it's listening. Sometimes it's knowing when to step back instead of cracking down. So no, don't make this an example. Leave this with me. Let me talk to her and help her find her footing because that was a good kid asking for help the only way she could manage, and if we're being honest... if we're really being honest, then I didn't catch that soon enough

The teacher looks at his peers as a silence falls over the room. The other teachers look at each other, not knowing what to say. The teacher waits for a beat to see the other's reactions, and then puts his glasses on and stands up, he pushes his chair back, takes a deep breath in, and nods at his peers before walking out of the room, as a long silence follows his exit.

CUT TO BLACK

END